DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY



WEST BENGAL

ABHISHEK TO THE FORE

By Romita Datta

The black SUV screeched to a halt outside the new Trinamool Congress (TMC) office on EM Bypass, Kolkata. Clad in a kurta-pyjama, Trinamool Congress general secretary Abhishek Banerjee stepped out and waved to the small crowd hanging around for a dekko, their curiosity piqued by the security bandobast. Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee's 35-year-old nephew had arrived for a press conference. Four senior TMC leaders had taken their seats; an imposing chair was kept vacant. Almost a quasi-coronation, reflecting the winds of change that have swept into the TMC's sails.

Abhishek took questions—even unsavoury ones, quite unruffled. To anyone watching, the message communicated itself through that very self-assurance: the next generation of the party leadership is ready to hit the showrooms. The presser on July 28 was Abhishek's first after former state minister and party veteran Partha Chatterjee fell into the dragnet cast by the Enforcement Directorate, which is probing the money trail in the alleged teachers' recruitment scam. Though the party had distanced itself from Chatterjee, it flailed around for days, with Mamata talking about the BJP's "vendetta politics".

Abhishek presented a stark contrast as soon as he took charge of the matter. After announcing the decision to strip Chatterjee of all party and government posts, he sent out a dire warning: "At TMC, there will be zero tolerance towards corruption." Abhishek also made it clear the onus was on Chatterjee to prove his innocence—a departure from the party's past support for leaders like Sudip Bandyopadhyay, Madan Mitra, Firhad Hakim and Subrata Mukherjee during the Narada scam days. This was in line with the image Abhishek has been exuding for years: of waging a lone battle for a full-on ethical cleansing of the TMC.

THE SUPREMO IN WAITING IS RECASTING TRINAMOOL IN A CLEANER PUBLIC MOULD

After the 2016 assembly polls, he is said to have fiercely opposed Saradha- and Narada-tainted leaders like Hakim, Mukherjee, Sovon Chatterjee and Mitra being in the cabinet. Since Mamata disagreed, he even boycotted the swearing-in do. That show of rectitude proves its utility now.

Following the 2019 Lok Sabha election, when an